

THE "LA DIVINA PASTORA/SUPAREE KE MAI" DEVOTIONS OF TRINIDAD

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The island of Trinidad is situated just above ten degrees latitude in the Caribbean Sea. It is the southernmost island in the Caribbean, under 5,000 square kilometres in area and only about ten to fifteen kilometres from Venezuela. According to the 1980 statistics from the Central Statistical Office of Trinidad and Tobago, the population is just about 1.1 million with 32.9 percent Roman Catholic, 14.7 percent Anglican, 24.9 percent Hindu, 6 percent Muslim and 3.8 percent Presbyterian. The remaining 17.7 percent may be accounted for as follows: 1.4 percent Wesleyan or Methodist, 2.4 percent Baptist, 2.5 percent Seventh Day Adventist, 0.8 percent Jehovah Witness, 3.45 percent Pentecostal and 6.1 percent with no stated religion.¹ Though this breakdown shows that the island is predominantly Christian there is still a large (30.9 percent) Hindu and Muslim community, which is accounted for by the history of colonization and the policies of colonization in the island. This will also explain the wide ethnic cross-section found even within the Roman Catholic Church.

The inclusion of Trinidad into the Spanish Empire began with Columbus' arrival in 1498. This set the tone for the Roman Catholic dimension to the island, whose hegemony was threatened by the surrender of the island to the British in the nineteenth century. It was at this time that anglicanism was introduced along with protestantism in general, and though the former was given the status of the official religion of the island for a few decades in the mid-nineteenth century, it did not stem the continued influence of the Roman Catholic Church in the island, nor bring about a serious haemorrhage from the Roman Catholic to the Anglican Church. Within this wide Christian administrative umbrella there were of course the African slaves who made up the bulk of the population and who thus unofficially made up the vast majority of the Christian population. Of more interest to us here though is the arrival of about 144,000 East Indian indentured labourers during the period 1845 to 1917. It was during those years in particular that the island received the influx of French planters from the rest of the West Indies, especially Grenada and Guadeloupe, and the Chinese and Syrian merchants and shop owners that are now present in the established Christian churches of the island. As a result of this hotchpotch of ethnic and religious differences, Trinidad finds itself in perhaps a unique position of reflexively being a bed of popular religiosity, but more so of being the crucible of syncretic amalgams that give expression to the religious impulses of its people.

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Obviously, with the established churches upholding and furthering in general the aims and policies of the ruling colonizing powers,² the popular religious expressions of the former slaves and indentured workers and their descendants were always suppressed and looked upon with disdain as of a "lower" religious form. But with the island claiming independence from the British Empire in 1962 and the institution of more indigenous leadership at both secular and religious levels, the popular religious expressions of the people gained greater momentum and have asserted their right for "respectable" inclusion in the lives of persons in the country. It is in this scenario that the dreaded Obeah, as the dark side of influencing spirits, and Shango/Orisha, the syncretic merging of traditional Yoruba African religion and Christianity, especially with regard to the ancestral spirits and the saints and the Virgin Mary, are to be understood as gaining importance. However, there is one popular religious festival that is unique to the Trinidad situation which shows how the religious impulse of a people cannot be stifled, and that is the *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* feast, which is celebrated in the main by Roman Catholics and Hindus alike, but also by other Christians as well as Muslims and persons of other faiths. This is not to say that Roman Catholics and Hindus have been in agreement over this feast, but over the years a hesitant respect has grown with regard to its being a shared feast and not solely the province of the Roman Catholics. Before giving a presentation on the feast, let me draw a brief socio-economic picture of the island, especially with regard to religion and to some extent class, since they are fairly intertwined in Trinidad.

The island under colonial rule was chiefly a sugar economy, which was rather average in terms of its financial worth. In that system Christians were the administrators, land owners, merchants, professionals, civil servants and anyone of "worth" in the island. Hindus, Muslims and others fulfilled the menial tasks of the island, especially in terms of field work. To belong to the Christian church was thus a measure of class, and to the Roman Catholic church, a sign that one had "reached." This explains the mostly East Indian population of the Presbyterian Church in Trinidad, since it was the only Christian church that accepted Hindu and Muslim converts as part of its missionary thrust, and later on the induction of well-to-do East Indian families into the Roman Catholic Church. With the oil boom of the 1970s, the island achieved a measure of wealth that served to bolster the courage of those who were traditionally looked upon as belonging to "lesser" churches. Coupled with the Black Power movement of the early 1970s, financial security translated into the desire and need to give more expression to our own local expressions, religious and otherwise. This gave impetus not only to the Christian churches but also to the East Indian and other communities to be more confident of their own localized and indigenous religious expressions and more so to present these fearlessly and with some pride. Unfortunately, this optimism and the financial security that bolstered it has gone, and now in the '90s it seems that not only have we not risen to, and implemented, the vision of the '70s, but we no longer have the socio-economic base from which to dream dreams.³ It is in this light that popular religiosity in Trinidad and indeed in the Caribbean⁴ is

being seen anew as the locus that requires explicit attention and involvement insofar as it is the expression of the vital and gut-level concerns of our people. In this context let me now turn to the festival of *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai*.

The feast of *La Divina Pastora* (the Holy Shepherdess) and *Suparee Ke Mai* (Mother Kali) are the Christian and Hindu aspects of a celebration that are rooted in the cultural and religious values of the people of Trinidad. For over a period of a hundred years it has attracted Hindus, Muslims as well as non-Catholic Christian groups to a shrine in Siparia (a village in the south east central part of the island) dedicated to *La Divina Pastora*. The Roman Catholic feast is itself celebrated the second Sunday after Easter, but Hindu and Muslim devotees especially go on pilgrimage there on Holy Thursday and Good Friday.

The Catholic origin of the feast⁵ hails back to Andalusia in Southern Spain in the early eighteenth century where it is held that Mary, the mother of the God-Man Jesus, appeared to a monk, Isidore of Seville, in the guise of an Andalusian shepherdess and made known to him that her role is to bring people into the sheepfold of her divine son. Isidore was a Cappuchin monk and this order brought the Holy Shepherdess devotion with them as early as 1715 in their mission to the South American mainland, especially to what is now known as Venezuela. In 1759 they formed a mission in Siparia in Trinidad apparently fleeing persecution by the Amerindians from the South American mainland from as early as 1730. With them apparently came the statue, which is held in reverence in the shrine. The statue itself makes interesting comparison with other statues of Mary. It is short, possesses long black hair, copper-coloured skin, small cheeks, kindly eyes and a tiny nose. It is this statue that is carried in solemn procession through the streets of Siparia during which the rosary is recited and marian hymns sung. Of course the popularity of the devotion is also due to the many miracles said to have taken place and innumerable favours granted. Siparia itself at the time of the arrival of the Cappuchins was a centre for the Guaranon Indians known as the "Warwarrhoons," who carried out a lively trade in Trinidad in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries and this popular devotion found easy identification with them, especially with its feasting, litany praying, procession with a statue and favour seeking — all similar elements of the Amerindian religious way of life.

The Roman Catholic perspective on the feast has thus traditionally understood the feast as an opportunity to shepherd all into the fold of Jesus Christ, an opportunity for evangelization that has significantly caused many a parish priest to attempt, with insignificant success, to convert non-Catholic devotees to *La Divina Pastora* to Roman catholicism. Further to this, Roman Catholics also think of the feast as really "their feast," which has been and is being distorted by other denominations. However, along with all other devotees, Roman Catholics also understand the Holy Shepherdess as an aid in time of need and one who grants favours and ensures proper guidance and protection. As we will see, this is no different from either the Hindu, Muslim or other religious devotees' understanding of the Mother of Siparia.

The East Indian dimension to the feast grew out of events that occurred during their period of indentureship. Originally East Indians came (from 1845) on a labour contract first for three, then for five years. This was extended to ten years with a guaranteed free return passage to India. So for the first twenty years or so the East Indian immigrant had no intention of settling down in Trinidad. The chief aim was to finish one's contract in the sugar cane fields, save as much money as possible and then return to India. Trinidad was an alien land to the East Indian, and their encounter with the Africans and the Christian religions was a strange and bewildering one. However, two events occurred in Trinidad that had consequences for the feast of *La Divina Pastora* with respect to the East Indians.

In 1870, Governor Gordon decided to give a block of crown lands to the East Indians who were desirous of making their home in Trinidad in return for their free passage to India. The response was so good that other East Indians began to apply for lands and as a result East Indian villages began to spring up, mainly in the north-central, central and south-central parts of the island. The next event was the opening up of the interior of Trinidad with the coming of the railway in the 1870s and its extension in the 1880s. This allowed easy access to the south of the island and Siparia then became accessible by rail to East Indians. It is not known exactly when they began to identify *La Divina Pastora* with *Suparee Ke Mai*, which really is an acknowledgement of Mother Kali, one of the more popular goddesses of the Hindu belief system. By 1890, however, the statue of *La Divina Pastora* was already attracting a large number of East Indians, especially Hindus, but also Muslims.

It is easy to understand their attraction to *La Divina Pastora*. Goddess Kali is the goddess of famine, destruction, plagues, epidemics, illnesses and other forms of disaster. Indentureship in Trinidad was a gruelling time for the East Indians in that they encountered not only a hostile environment but had also to endure harsh sugar plantation life that was nothing less than a new form of slavery. Their living conditions were subhuman and they contracted all kinds of illnesses, as well as consuming quantities of alcohol, smoking *ganja* and being subject to a fair number of murders as a result of marital infidelity. When it was brought to their attention that favours were granted through the intercession of Mary as represented by the statue, they readily came to her and saw her as Mother Kali. To her they poured out their woes, sorrows, distress. Barren wives would ask for children, young children would have their first long locks cut off as a sign of dedication and offering. The sick would ask for healing, young girls for proper husbands and beggars for the alleviation of distress. As the East Indians were under the planter's control, the public holiday of Good Friday was their chosen day to do homage to the Goddess Kali, when they would travel by train singing Hindu devotional hymns. Important for these devotees was the offering of jewelry, gold and silver bracelets, chains and rings, candles, oil and money, either in supplication or in thanksgiving. Usually for thanksgiving Indian dances would be performed by colourfully clad dancers and help would be given to beggars and less fortunate members of society as acts of piety.

The East Indian attachment to the feast, though not having an “evangelizing” component to it, is not dissimilar to the Christian understanding of the same, in that both understandings generate around the intercessory, restorative, placating and generative powers of *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai*. And it is to be noted that the method of devotion to *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* has not changed significantly since the nineteenth century. Devotees still bring offerings to her and young children still have their first haircut in her presence. Indeed, over the years the real problem with *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* has not been with regard to its efficacy but with regard to “whose feast” is it really? In that regard the Roman Catholic Church has always laid claim to it, to the extent that in the 1920s attempts were made to prevent East Indians from coming to the shrine and a notice to that effect was made public in five languages. The police were even called in to implement the decree but the attempt proved a failure. Continuously over the years various parish priests have attempted a variety of strategies such as moving the statue out of the shrine, but the resultant upheaval (among Catholics themselves who want the statue in the shrine) has always seen the statue and the locus of devotion return to the shrine. In more recent years, the feasting aspect of the festival has gained prominence so that the days in and around the feast are now known as *Siparia Fete*. Only recently the community of Siparia argued with the parish priest over his decision to bring the feast forward by one week. They argue that “Siparia owns *La Divina* and *La Divina* owns Siparia,”⁶ in other words, the feast really is a “community affair” where the community could derive some commercial profit and not only a “church affair.” It would seem that all expressions of popular religion eventually have to deal with this aspect of them, but let us now attempt some clarification of the issues offered to us by the feast of *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* in Trinidad.

Clearly, the feast has correlates in many other parts of the world in that the worship of a Black Virgin is not uncommon to this part of the world (Our Lady of Guadeloupe for instance), nor does the popular devotion to Mary lack enthusiasm the world over. As a matter of fact, there was a time when such enthusiasm was discouraged in Roman catholicism because it seemed to supersede the “official” liturgical expressions. So another popular religious festival to Mary of itself is interesting but hardly new. What is unique, however, in the Trinidad experience is the use of the feast, and of the statue, by Hindus regarding it as a representation of Kali. More than this, that such devotion should survive the attempts to stamp out such “superstition,” and also resist conversion, is a striking and instructive event in the religious life of a people. It hints at a reality that we must take into account if we are to seriously and respectfully appreciate popular religiosity, and if we are to understand the possibilities (if at all) of evangelization in such contexts.

First, it seems to me, as I think it does to everyone, that the popular religious expression arises out of the perceived hopes and desires of persons. This is why they persist and that is what accounts for their enduring character. More than this, it also explains why popular religious expression will always find an

avenue of expression. In effect, stifling popular religiosity is a stifling of the psyche, the spirit of persons. Perhaps that is why in Trinidad, as in the rest of the Caribbean and in other third world countries, popular religiosity survives as a form of resistance more than as a formal structure with clarified metalanguages (theologies). Indeed, it is as such that *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* continues to thrive, despite the attempts by the Roman Catholic Church in the persons of the various parish priests of Siparia to regulate and formalize the proceedings. There is a lesson to be learned here. As much as we would like to harness the vibrant and compelling impulse found in the Siparia devotions and in all popular religiosity, it would seem that one has to be careful to allow the expression under study to remain what it is, not what we would like it to be. We must always be careful not to stifle, in terms of regulatory formalization, the expressions of the spirit of our people.

This brings up the second point that one of the reasons for interpreting the Hindu use of *La Divina Pastora* as "superstitious" and "inferior" in status is that of fear. Fear that some sort of horrible magic was and is being worked right in our own backyard so to speak; but more than that, the fear that arises out of the ignorance of another's religious traditions and meanings. It is rare that one would read something like this Siparia parish record written in 1871 by a Fr Cornelius O'Hanlon:⁷

For the East Indians, the Black Virgin is really "Suparee"; the name of a seed which is used in their religious ceremonies; and also the name of a powerful saint in India . . . who never fails to come to help in the hour of need. When their ancestors came to Trinidad, the Indians heard of the "Saint" at Siparia . . . found that she had all the qualities of the Suparee-Mai; and were convinced that she was the same one. They referred to her as "Suparee-Ke-Mai," rather than "La Divina Pastora."

But even such awareness was used with the aim of "correcting" the misunderstanding of the Hindus with regard to who the statue "really" represents. Clearly we have to be careful that we do not go along with popular religiosity because it suits our purpose in terms of imposing our own understanding of reality and events on others. As a matter of fact, parish records in Siparia clearly show that converts are not had simply because diverse peoples share a common physical and geographical referent and thereby seemingly have "common" ground. On the contrary, the Hindus in the main have remained staunchly Hindu and other Christian and religious devotees have also maintained the structures of belief they came with in their devotional practices to *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai*. It seems, then, that if we are talking evangelization in terms of popular religion we are not necessarily talking about converts. Indeed, perhaps we have to consider the dubious wisdom of approaching popular religiosity within a framework of evangelization. While in Guyana recently attending an inter-faith conference, a member of the Winty religion, a "popular religion" in Suriname similar to the Shango/Orisha in Trinidad, to Pocomania in Jamaica and Voodoo in Haiti, told me that he gets angry when so-called "established" religions want to understand Winty so that they could incorporate or translate some of their elements in order to attract

Winty followers. He was angered by the arrogance and lack of respect shown to Winty followers and also by our branding the religion as “popular,” meaning by that, that it is not really a cohesive unit with a solid core of basic beliefs and understandings. I think we must take this critique seriously and question the whole *raison d'être* for our wanting to link evangelization with popular religiosity. Why evangelize that which already is a fulfilling expression of what we understand the gospel to be? It could be that we may be the ones who require evangelization in terms of learning the lessons of supporting, giving, sharing and living life, which seem so enshrined in popular religiosity and so lacking in our formal liturgies and metalanguages (theologies). This leads to my third point.

What is liberating about the *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* feast is not so much the symbolism involved, but the opportunity to invoke and restore such symbolism in the lives of a people. It is in the midst of the hardship of indentureship that the East Indian in search of a “home” finds that home not only in a physical sense but in the religious sense that covers his range of expression. In effect, *Suparee Ke Mai* allows the worship of the goddess Kali just as the Caroni River takes the place of the river Ganges for the local Hindu. So that once there is that space, either created or already established (as in this case) to allow for the adequate expression of the hopes and pains of a people, there we will find the vibrancy that supports and carries popular religiosity. I think this means that perhaps we should not be so concerned with evangelization in regard to popular religions but with trying to set up structures of receptivity so that we may listen with respect. This is vitally important, for if we are not able nor willing to set up structures to listen and learn from the religious impulses of our people, then we will not only be doomed to official superstructures that find themselves alienated from our people, but we will thereby find any hint at evangelization met not with argument (which would be a blessing in that some dialogue is taking place), but with calm indifference. This is a frightening yet real scenario and one we must meet realistically.

In the end, what *La Divina Pastora/Suparee Ke Mai* offers us is the opportunity to respect one another out of which may then grow the seeds of evangelization on both sides. So that as we impart our message to others, we in turn learn the value of their message and in this learning revise not only our approaches but our very structures of living so that the Holy Shepherdess and Mother Kali may indeed grant us the favours of understanding and unity as a people. Perhaps the challenge really is how much we can “evangelize” ourselves towards a more healthy understanding of so-called popular religions.

NOTES

¹ M. Rouse-Jones, "Changing Patterns of Denominational Affiliation," in *Social and Occupational Stratification in Contemporary Trinidad and Tobago*, Selwyn Ryan ed., St Augustine, Trinidad: Institute of Social and Economic Research, The University of the West Indies, pp. 350-374, 354.

² See Idris Hamid, ed., *Out of the Depths*, St Andrews Theological College, San Fernando, Trinidad, for a collection of papers that echo this theme.

³ This is one of the more important points brought out in a consultation on theological education within the Caribbean held in Jamaica from 23-29 January 1993.

⁴ Again a concern of the consultation held in Jamaica and also of the first inter-faith conference of the Caribbean held in Georgetown, Guyana during the first weekend in April 1993.

⁵ Taken from an introduction to Novena Prayers written by Thomas Harricharan OSB.

⁶ "Holy War Brews in Siparia," the *Sunday Express*, 9 May 1993, p. 2.

⁷ Taken from Carlos Roberts, "La Divina Pastora," *Pastoral Bulletin*, Vol. 7 No. 4, Easter 1992, p. 14.